

CHAPTER TWO

Evidence

Between 2009 and 2019, something almost previously unthinkable occurred: Veteran homelessness in the United States fell by nearly half—a decline of about thirty-six thousand people who were without housing on any given night.¹ The progress was unambiguously good news, not least because it occurred in the wake of the financial crisis. Indeed, statistics on veteran homelessness would soon become a rallying cry for housing advocates and many urban policymakers: With enough money and attention, the injustice of a former soldier sleeping outside might be relegated to the pages of history books. But to the uninitiated observer, this policy success might also be puzzling. As the journalist J. B. Wogan wrote, most people experiencing homelessness are not veterans, and “in many of the nation’s large cities, homelessness among the general population appears to be getting worse. . . . Right now, it’s hard to say whether success in lowering homelessness will be limited to veterans, or whether this will be the first step in a longer campaign to fight homelessness among the rest of the population.”² How had the country

become so good at housing veterans and their families? And what about those who haven't served in the armed forces?

Certainly, the social standing of military veterans helps explain the political (and financial) commitments that were necessary to achieve this progress—few politicians disagree with the notion that a nation should support the people who risked their lives defending it—but a pressing question remains as to whether similar commitments can and will be applied more broadly, rather than toward a targeted few. Even in the case of veterans, the job remains unfinished. Policymakers mobilized the bureaucratic machinery of several federal agencies (including the Department of Veterans Affairs) to find and fund the necessary housing and institutional pipelines required to meet the needs of unhoused veterans—and still, half the military veteran population experiencing homelessness remains unhoused. To imagine replicating (and maybe doubling) this effort for all populations experiencing homelessness is perhaps a daunting task. But there is an organizing principle here: one of context-specific, systemic effort.

In this book, we argue that if we understand homelessness as a housing problem, we can also understand it as solvable. And as a scholarly and policy community, we already have the evidence that it is. By no stretch of the imagination are housed veterans the only success story homelessness policymakers and service-delivery organizations have to offer. As Beth Shinn and Jill Khadduri argue in their recent book, *In the Midst of Plenty, Homelessness and What to Do About It*, the necessary resources exist to end homelessness—the constraints are political will and commitment.³ In other words, that homelessness still persists in the United States should not be taken as evidence that investments and programs designed to address the crisis have failed. Instead,

we can only understand existing policies and programs as inadequate. The persistence of the problem of homelessness reflects these deficiencies.

In this chapter, we describe how we and other researchers have reached this conclusion. In particular, we review the existing body of academic and public research to answer five questions that will help frame the analysis found in the rest of the book:

1. What is the current landscape of homelessness in the United States?
2. How has homelessness changed over time?
3. How do we explain homelessness?
4. What are the consequences of homelessness?
5. How do we stop and prevent homelessness?

We confront these questions in turn.

WHAT IS THE CURRENT LANDSCAPE OF HOMELESSNESS IN THE UNITED STATES?

Unlike previous eras characterized by high rates of homelessness in the country, today's crisis comes at a time of unparalleled wealth and prosperity. During the Great Depression, homeless encampments dotted the landscape of many U.S. cities—a tragic but conceivable outcome. As the unemployment rate in the 1930s soared to 25 percent and economic activity ground to a halt, many could no longer afford their housing, and homelessness became all too common. Today, though, U.S. cities look very different than they did during the Depression. Homelessness looks different, too. People regularly establish encampments in the shadows of glistening office towers that house the employees of

modern corporate titans in technology and finance. This incongruity is a source of confusion for many observers.

One of the first researchers to help explain this ostensible paradox was Brendan O’Flaherty, who confronted it head-on—arguing in 1996 that “income inequality is behind the increased homelessness in North America.”⁴ O’Flaherty offered an economic explanation for the relationship: namely, that as people with comparatively lower incomes were squeezed out of higher-quality housing, they pushed prices up at the lower end of the housing market, ultimately forcing those with the lowest incomes into homelessness. Whatever the explanation—and much of this book is devoted to testing hypotheses like these—trying to understand homelessness without placing it in the broader context of the housing market is a fool’s errand. Here, we’ll often think about the housing market as many economists do: that is, as a system in which *housing services* are dynamically allocated to households based on their *preferences* and *ability to pay*. Through this lens, key issues that immediately come into focus include the stock of housing, the price of housing, and the resources of households.

Each year, a nonprofit advocacy organization called the National Low Income Housing Coalition (NLIHC) publishes a report entitled *The Gap: A Shortage of Affordable Homes*. Based on 2018 data, the most recent version of this report found that for every one hundred households with extremely low incomes, there exist only thirty-six affordable and available homes.⁵ This shortage of housing units presents a clear and present threat to the health and viability of this large block of households. A quarter of all renters in the United States have extremely low incomes. Despite significant variation across the country, no state offers adequate housing for households with extremely low

incomes: West Virginia is the only state with sixty affordable and available homes for every one hundred households who need them. According to the NLIHC, the West Coast has the most pronounced shortages of affordable housing; Oregon, California, Nevada, and Arizona all have fewer than thirty units for every one hundred households in need.

To begin to understand how these dynamics map onto the phenomenon of homelessness, it is instructive—by way of example—to provide an overview of the housing market in one metropolitan area. Consider Hennepin County, Minnesota, where Minneapolis is located. Based on five-year estimates from the American Community Survey (ACS), Hennepin County was home to 1,235,279 people in 2018. Using data from the ACS, HUD’s Picture of Subsidized Households, and the National Housing Preservation Database, we estimate that there are about 530,000 housing units in Hennepin County, which we can in turn break down into three categories: unsubsidized (owned), unsubsidized (rented), and subsidized (rented). As in many regions of the country, owner-occupancy is the dominant form of housing tenure: Over 62 percent of housing units are owned. The remaining 38 percent of housing units are rented, and the vast majority are units that renters access via the private market. Less than 7 percent of all housing units are subsidized through federal programs like the Housing Choice Voucher Program, public housing, place-based Section 8, or Low-Income Housing Tax Credits.⁶

Given consistent population growth, the overall demand for housing in Hennepin County is strong. The region’s housing market is also tight: Rental market vacancy rates—that is, the percentage of units available for rent at any given point in time—have hovered at or below 4 percent since 2012. The

combination of these market dynamics and general lack of subsidized housing options presents a serious housing challenge for low-income households in Hennepin County. In practice, that means many households are scrambling to meet their housing needs. In 2018, just over 10 percent of people in Hennepin County were living in households with incomes below the federal poverty line. (For comparison, that's a bit lower than the nationwide rate of 13 percent). That year, the poverty line in 2018 was \$12,140 for an individual household and \$25,100 for a household of four. The number of households living under this definition of poverty far exceeded the quantity of subsidized housing units in Hennepin County that year. Because only 6.6 percent of units are subsidized, thousands of households living in poverty were left with no choice but to procure unsubsidized housing in the private market.

Like most markets for goods and services, the market for housing consists of a wide range of options that differ in terms of quality and price. But the existence of lower-priced housing options does not necessarily imply an adequate supply of affordable housing for all households that need it. In Hennepin County, the twenty-fifth percentile contract rent was \$814/month in 2018. If we assume that an affordable rent is that which stays below, say, 30 percent of household income, this theoretical rental unit at the twenty-fifth percentile—including an additional \$93 for utility payments each month—would only be affordable to households earning at least \$35,760 per year: much higher than the poverty threshold for a family of four.⁷ Data from the NLIHC corroborates these statistics.⁸ In Minnesota, there are only forty-one affordable and available rental homes per one hundred extremely low-income renter households. The remaining fifty-nine households are in an exceedingly difficult position

where, in order to keep a roof over their heads, they must devote a significant percentage of their limited income each month to rent—leaving little money for other household necessities.

For households unable to secure one of the five hundred thirty thousand housing units in Hennepin County, there are two additional options. First, a household can “double-up” with another household until they can secure their own housing. The other alternative is to turn to a county-run homelessness response system that provides temporary shelter or some form of permanent housing to those in need. Hennepin County is one of a limited number of jurisdictions in the country with a “right to shelter” policy, which guarantees shelter to any person or family who needs it. Accordingly, the county has a system in place that allows shelter capacity to expand and contract based on the present need for shelter services. Despite this right to shelter, Hennepin County still reported an unsheltered homeless count of 404 people in 2018 during its one-night census. Another 2,609 (87%) were sleeping in emergency shelters or transitional housing facilities. The homelessness response system in Hennepin County includes both emergency shelters and various forms of permanent housing for households in need, including permanent supportive housing and rapid rehousing.⁹ The sum of these two populations—the unsheltered and sheltered homeless, in the parlance of HUD—suggests an estimated 3,013 people were without permanent housing in Hennepin County in 2018. On the same night as this point-in-time (PIT) count in Hennepin County, another 8,545 people were living in some form of permanent housing supported by the county’s homelessness response system. Whether via short-term rental assistance or long-term subsidized units, the county had funded and operated programs that had *ended* program participants’

homelessness crisis in the eyes of HUD. Accordingly, these people were not included in the annual homelessness census, despite currently receiving some form of housing subsidy only available to people who had previously experienced homelessness. This delineation—between unsheltered homelessness, temporary housing (sheltered homelessness), and permanent housing—reflects the federal definition of what constitutes homelessness and what doesn't. The point is: At least 3,000 people in Hennepin County needed a more permanent place to sleep on the night of the census.

This brief sketch of the housing system in Hennepin County highlights two critical points about the country as a whole. First, the supply of subsidized housing in the United States is limited by the relatively modest resources the federal government provides for housing assistance. An expansion of these benefits would provide needed support to low-income households in metropolitan areas around the country. Second, permanent housing programs within the homelessness response system are critical tools for moving people out of homelessness. In Hennepin County, of the 11,558 people who reside outside the bounds of the conventional housing market, roughly 74 percent reside in such permanent housing programs, almost 23 percent rely on emergency shelters and transitional housing facilities, and the remaining 3.5 percent are without shelter. If you accept the federal definition of homelessness—that is, as the state of sleeping outside (or other places not meant for habitation), in an emergency shelter, or in a transitional housing facility—then, by definition, greater investments in subsidized housing and the system of permanent housing programs could provide the housing that is needed to eliminate homelessness in many metropolitan areas in the country. Given the scope of the housing system in

Hennepin County—over five hundred thirty thousand housing units—a relatively modest increase in permanent housing (even on the scale of, say, three thousand units) shouldn't represent an insurmountable task.

But not every county is Hennepin. As most popular perceptions of homelessness are driven by the state of the issue in large coastal cities, we now turn our attention to the nation's two largest cities: New York and Los Angeles. According to the 2019 PIT count, New York City is home to the largest unhoused population in the country.¹⁰ The composition of homelessness differs meaningfully in New York from other regions of the country: In New York, of the 78,604 people experiencing homelessness on a single night in 2019, nearly 92 percent were housed in emergency shelters while only 4.6 percent were unsheltered. (Compare this unsheltered rate to Hennepin County's 13 percent). This distribution differs meaningfully from Los Angeles County, where a far greater proportion of the homeless population is also unsheltered. The difference between New York City and Los Angeles can partially be explained by policy: New York City has a right-to-shelter law like Hennepin County, and, as a result, the city has built a comprehensive shelter system that far exceeds the shelter capacity provided by any other city in the country.

A review of the Housing Inventory Count, a report published annually by HUD for each Continuum of Care in the country, breaks down this housing support system. In 2019, New York City had 111,605 year-round beds for families and individuals in need. Included in that bed count were 75,245 emergency shelter beds and 33,203 associated with the types of permanent housing programs outlined in the previous section. (Recall that people living in the latter are not included in the federal definition of homelessness.) This substantial commitment to housing, combined

with the right-to-shelter policy, helps to explain the relatively low rate of unsheltered homelessness in New York City.

From the perspective of the homelessness response system, Los Angeles looks very different. Of the 56,257 people experiencing homelessness—according to the 2019 PIT count—more than 75 percent live outside the emergency shelter system and are classified as unsheltered. Just under 11,000 people sleep in shelters in Los Angeles. Like New York, L.A. has a robust supply of beds associated with permanent housing programs (28,887). These permanent units are a critical tool used to keep people out of homelessness. The main takeaway from this comparison is that New York has a significant problem with homelessness that it currently addresses with a robust emergency shelter system. Additional investments in affordable housing and permanent housing within the homeless response system could help to limit the number of individuals and families that end up staying in one of the city's many homeless shelters. Los Angeles confronts a very different reality. L.A. could follow New York and greatly expand its emergency shelter capacity in the hopes of dramatically reducing its population of unsheltered people. But creating additional shelter capacity doesn't end homelessness: It recharacterizes it. People sleeping in shelters are still homeless—per the federal definition. A pressing question for cities like Los Angeles is whether to invest scarce resources to expand shelter capacity—in order to limit the number of people sleeping on the streets—or to apply those resources toward the development of more permanent forms of housing designed to end homelessness. This conundrum is at the heart of a housing policy challenge for other West Coast cities with high rates of unsheltered homelessness, including San Francisco, Portland, and Seattle.

Nationally, about five hundred sixty-eight thousand people experienced homelessness on a single night in 2019. Of those people, 63 percent were sheltered, either in emergency shelters or transitional housing facilities, and 37 percent were unsheltered—sleeping in tents, cars, abandoned buildings, parks, and other places not intended for human habitation. Just as the variety of homelessness experienced by Americans is not uniform, the identities and demographics of people without permanent housing vary considerably. For example, about 30 percent of the people experiencing homelessness are members of families, while the remaining 70 percent are in single-member households. Despite perceptions to the contrary, homelessness isn't just a condition experienced by mature adults: About 27 percent of people experiencing homelessness are twenty-four years old and younger. The vast majority of these young people are sheltered, but almost twenty-seven thousand are without shelter on a given night.

As with countless other injustices in the United States, homelessness is far from evenly distributed across races and ethnicities. Most notably, Black people are disproportionately represented in the homeless population: While Black people account for only 13 percent of the U.S. population, 40 percent of all people experiencing homelessness on any given night are Black. This racial disproportionality must undergird any analysis of homelessness in the country. Decades of overt and structural racism—in lending practices and employment opportunities, eviction rates and over-policing, from Jim Crow to the present day—have made it far too easy to lose your housing if you live in the United States and you're Black. Indigenous people, too, are at least three times more likely to experience homelessness in the United States than what one would expect given their proportion of the general population. And as

researchers at the Center for Social Innovation noted recently, “Poverty alone does not explain the inequity. The proportion of Black and American Indian and Alaska Native individuals experiencing homelessness exceeds their proportion of those living in deep poverty.”¹¹ While pathways into homelessness are knotty and imbued with all the complexities of individual experience, reasons for such disproportionately racialized rates of homelessness are readily available—and intuitive, given the country’s broad oppression (and subsequent exclusion) of specific groups. Writing broadly, Shinn and Khadduri highlight four forms of social exclusion that provide a link between race and homelessness: lower incomes, less wealth accumulation, housing discrimination, and disproportionate rates of incarceration.¹² Each manifestation of exclusion acts to destabilize one’s housing environment and can increase the likelihood of losing one’s housing altogether. We return to race as a potential explanation for *regional variation* in the next chapter.

As race illustrates, homelessness is experienced differently by different people. And while this is a book about cities, it’s worth understanding some of these experiences. A common tool used by researchers and analysts to understand homelessness is to identify three different categories of homelessness based on length of time spent without housing. Kuhn and Culhane, for example, used cluster analysis of homelessness spells to define a typology of homelessness with three categories: transitional, episodic, and chronic.¹³ Those who are transitionally homeless lose their housing and interact with a homelessness response system (say, an emergency shelter) for brief periods of time. Episodic homelessness involves frequent entries into and exits from homelessness. People experiencing chronic homelessness remain unhoused for long periods of time—up to a year or longer.¹⁴ A

typology of homelessness matters because housing programs—and people’s responses to these programs—depend on a variety of one’s experiences with homelessness. For example, people who are chronically homeless often have more significant barriers to housing stability, including deep poverty, physical or mental health conditions, and substance-use issues, and by extension, will often need more than a little rent support to remain housed. Those who are transitionally homeless or homeless for the first-time might just need shelter, cash assistance, or employment support as they get back on their feet.

But these classifications of homelessness are important for another reason: When researchers analyze the annual one-night homelessness census, that cross-sectional view may not provide an accurate picture of this phenomenon. Consider the following hypothetical example in which there are two varieties of homelessness: chronic (longer than one year) and short-term (one month). Suppose a city conducts a PIT count in January—a cross-sectional estimate of the size of the homeless population—and finds ten people who are currently without housing: nine people experiencing short-term homelessness and one person experiencing chronic homelessness. This count would suggest that, on any given night, 10 percent of the city’s homeless population is chronically homeless. But suppose this same city were to conduct a homeless census every month of the year. In February, for example, again the city surveys its unhoused population, and again the total count is ten. In this case, while the same chronically homeless person is included in this list of ten people, nine people the city hadn’t seen the previous month are now experiencing short-term homelessness. Perhaps the people who were temporarily homeless in January had found housing and were no longer included in the count. In any case, based on

the February count, 10 percent of the city's unhoused population is chronically homeless. But an analysis of both months together yields a very different conclusion: If we consider everyone who experienced homelessness in January and February—a period prevalence measure as opposed to a cross-sectional estimate—there are eighteen temporarily homeless people and one person who is chronically homeless. In other words, PIT estimates of the homeless population exaggerate the proportion of the population experiencing chronic homelessness. As the authors of one of the first studies to characterize the prevalence of homelessness over longer periods of time wrote, “Because these studies [covering shorter periods of time] overrepresent chronic, long-term homeless people, they distort our image of who becomes homeless and mistakenly overemphasize the importance of personal deficits as causes of homelessness.”¹⁵

Regardless of the method jurisdictions use to measure rates of homelessness, they're also faced with the central challenge of finding, identifying, and counting a hard-to-reach, often invisible population. Many researchers have highlighted the myriad difficulties facing CoCs as they attempt to measure the severity of homelessness.¹⁶ The National Homeless Law Center (formerly the National Law Center on Homelessness and Poverty, a Washington, D.C., non-profit), for example, has voiced multiple concerns with HUD's point-in-time counts. These points of objection include inconsistent methodology and definitions deployed by HUD over time, the undercount of unsheltered people—who are often more difficult to survey—and the fact that only certain types of housing instability meet the federal definition of homelessness.¹⁷ (For example, people staying with friends or family in doubled-up living situations after losing their own housing are excluded from official homelessness

statistics.) Researchers have used a variety of tools to test the validity and accuracy of the point-in-time count, and their results suggest that this approach meaningfully undercounts the population. Validation approaches range from planting research participants on the street to see if they'll be surveyed as part of a given jurisdiction's point-in-time count to statistical methods that estimate the degree of undercounting.¹⁸ Kim Hopper and colleagues found that 29 percent of their plants were not discovered in the homelessness count, suggesting a material undercount of the total population experiencing homelessness.¹⁹ Chris Glynn and Emily Fox leveraged statistical approaches to estimate the true population of people experiencing homelessness in the twenty-five largest cities in the country. Their findings suggest pervasive undercounting, with the estimated undercount far greater in cities with high rates of unsheltered homelessness (including Los Angeles, San Francisco, and Seattle). In New York, where the vast majority of people experiencing homelessness reside in shelters, the researchers' estimated actual 2016 count was about 4 percent higher than the HUD PIT estimates. In Los Angeles, the difference was almost 27 percent.²⁰ These caveats underly the many analyses that use these data to understand homelessness in the United States, including our own.

HOW HAS HOMELESSNESS CHANGED OVER TIME?

The modern era of homelessness began in the late 1970s and gained national attention during the recession of the early 1980s. As awareness of homelessness grew among policymakers and the general population, many imagined the phenomenon was a consequence of the economic downturn of the late 1970s and would

evaporate once the economy rebounded.²¹ Consistent with this perception, early efforts to address homelessness were managed by the Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA)—as if the crisis were temporary; akin to a flood or earthquake.

In light of a plainly growing problem, the federal government also sought to develop a greater understanding of the severity and scope of homelessness around the country. HUD conducted the first national PIT count in 1983–84, which revealed a national estimate of two hundred fifty thousand to three hundred fifty thousand people experiencing homelessness.²² Subsequent research by Richard Freeman and Brian Hall estimated a national homeless population of two hundred seventy-nine thousand in 1983 and a range of three hundred forty-three thousand to three hundred sixty-three thousand in 1985.²³ As Freeman and Hall wrote, “Economic recovery will not solve the problem of homelessness, and . . . in the absence of changes in the housing market or in the economic position of the very poor, the U.S. will continue to be plagued with a problem of homelessness for the foreseeable future.” The increase from 1983 to 1985 was particularly troubling to policymakers, because it came during a time of economic expansion. Given this evidence, scholars suggested that the kneejerk argument—that is, that an improving economy would ameliorate homelessness—was far from accurate.²⁴ By the close of the decade, those tasked with measuring the population of people experiencing homelessness agreed that the unhoused population in the country was in the range of two hundred thirty thousand to six hundred thousand. They also agreed the crisis was no earthquake. If nothing was done, homelessness would become a permanent fixture of American society.²⁵ In 1987, Freeman and Hall explained the problem of homelessness with echoes of today’s crisis:

While we are loath to generalize from a single area, the pattern of rapidly rising land values, rents, and housing market problems for the poor in Massachusetts raises the possibility that future economic progress, including full employment of the type enjoyed in Massachusetts, may exacerbate rather than alleviate the housing problems of the poor. One can easily devise a scenario in which economic growth raises demand for land, inducing landlords to develop higher-quality properties, pricing out of the market those whose incomes do not rise with the rate of growth.²⁶

We are now living in the researchers' "foreseeable future." The point-in-time estimates of homelessness from the 1980s suggested that between 0.11 percent and 0.25 percent of the U.S. population was homeless on any given night. It should not be lost on readers that these rates are very similar to that implied by the 2019 point-in-time count (0.17 percent). In 2007, HUD issued its first Annual Homeless Assessment Report to Congress based on data from 2005. In this study, an aggregation of CoCs' PIT counts, HUD estimated that 754,147 people had experienced homelessness on a single night in 2005—a number that, on a per capita basis, had not risen from a prior measure in 1996.²⁷ This count suggested that roughly one-quarter of one percent of the general population experienced homelessness at a single time—the high-water mark for post-1980 PIT estimates of homelessness in the country. By 2019, the rate had fallen to 0.17 percent. In sum, over the last forty years, between 0.11 percent and 0.25 percent of the general population has experienced homelessness, based on point-in-time counts.

Given the challenges of PIT estimates of homelessness outlined above, many researchers have argued for the use of longitudinal analyses to estimate the prevalence of homelessness—that is, the rate of people who experience homelessness *over* a given

period of time, whether, say, a year or the lifetime of a person. Following the earlier work of Bruce Link and colleagues, more recent research suggests a lifetime homelessness prevalence between 4.2 and 6.2 percent.²⁸ These estimates would suggest that HUD's estimate of five hundred sixty-eight thousand people experiencing homelessness is a gross mischaracterization of the issue. Many multiples of that number lose their housing during their lifetime, and—given the well-documented negative consequences of homelessness—large swaths of the U.S. population face significant barriers as they attempt to recover from a spell of homelessness.

HOW DO WE EXPLAIN HOMELESSNESS?

Abundant research and analysis support a wide range of potential causes and drivers of homelessness. As consumers of this information and data, it can be difficult to navigate this complex, and, at times, contradictory body of evidence. One important way to sift through and organize research on homelessness is to differentiate by unit of analysis. Some studies focus on the individual; others focus on geographic units (like cities, counties, or metropolitan areas). As Brendan O'Flaherty noted, "Studies that take as their unit of observation homelessness rates in different cities have generally found that housing market conditions have large effects. . . . By contrast, studies that take individuals as their unit of observation find weak effects for housing market conditions of the cities where the individuals find themselves, and strong effects for personal characteristics. The two types of studies seem to support contrasting policy advice: city-level studies say reduce rents and increase vacancies, individual-level studies say work on pathology and poverty."²⁹

O’Flaherty resolves this conflict by arguing that to understand homelessness, one needs to consider the interaction (in a statistical sense) between structural factors (like housing market dynamics) and individual factors (like job loss, mental illness, and addiction).³⁰ In this book, we argue that each set of factors is useful in its own right—depending on the question at hand. The distinction is hardly controversial. Studies concerning individual explanations of homelessness help to predict who, in a given city, will become homeless; and studies with cities as their unit of analysis help to explain why some regions see higher rates of homelessness than others. Because the latter question is the focus of this book, we’ll devote more narrative energy to summarizing the state of this type of analysis, but in this section, we also offer an overview of the individually based research on homelessness.

Individual Attributes

The vast majority of CEOs in the United States are men. Given the present state of corporate leadership and its recent history, one can’t help but concede that *maleness* increases the likelihood of becoming a CEO. And yet most of us understand the relationship between corporate leadership and gender to be a function of structural explanations that keep women out of leadership roles—among them sexism, unbalanced childcare responsibilities and parental leave policies, underpayment, and gatekeeping processes. Would we say that gender *causes* the apparent disproportionate representation of men in the C-Suite? Of course not. Gender interacts with other societal forces to produce a disparate outcome.

Are people with incomes below the federal poverty line more likely to experience homelessness than people with higher

incomes? The answer is, unequivocally, yes. Are people with severe mental illness at higher risk for homelessness? Most certainly, yes. Are Black people disproportionately represented in the homeless population? For all the reasons briefly outlined previously in this chapter, we know this to be true. And while disaggregating the population experiencing homelessness is an essential focus of homelessness research, demographic attributes are never inherently causal drivers of the problem at hand. We can think about individual attributes and their relationship to homelessness in two distinct manners. First, there are individual *vulnerabilities* (including poverty, mental illness, addiction, and domestic violence) that may increase the risk or likelihood of experiencing homelessness for any given person. Second, there are individual *attributes*—such as race and sexual orientation—that may increase the risk of homelessness when they interact with structural barriers like racism and other forms of discrimination and oppression. In the next chapter, we address the relationship between these factors and our object of interest: regional variation in homelessness.

A wide range of individual vulnerabilities and attributes are associated with higher rates of homelessness, including being male,³¹ unmarried,³² having low income,³³ being older,³⁴ being non-white³⁵ and identifying as LGBTQ—especially among youth.³⁶ In many of these cases, these personal attributes collide with societal discrimination or other forms of social exclusion to increase the likelihood that people with these characteristics experience homelessness. Interpersonal relationships (or the lack thereof) can also contribute to housing instability. Homelessness risk is greater for people with limited support from a community, low self-esteem, and a lack of belonging.³⁷ Researchers have also noted that people experiencing homelessness have fewer familial

ties and tend to live farther away from relatives than those who are housed.³⁸ Fertig and Reingold found that low levels of family support increase the risk of future homelessness.³⁹ In a confirmation of the psychological research underscoring the importance of social ties and connections, Corinth and Rossi-de Vries found, all else being equal, that strong social ties (especially among family) help to mitigate the risk of homelessness in adulthood.⁴⁰

In addition to personal attributes and relationships, there are a variety of individual vulnerabilities that also increase the risk of homelessness, including suffering from depression,⁴¹ experiencing mental illness or other psychiatric disorders,⁴² use or abuse of drugs and alcohol,⁴³ and having a criminal record or history of incarceration.⁴⁴ Researchers have found that many of these individual risk factors also increase the length of homelessness spells.⁴⁵

Arguably, the most common public and media narratives surrounding homelessness concerns addiction, mental illness, and behavioral health care—particularly among the chronic, unsheltered population. The use of illicit drugs, unhealthy levels of alcohol consumption, and severe mental health conditions are more heavily represented in the chronically homeless population than in the general public.⁴⁶ Several studies suggest that between 25 and 40 percent of the individual (i.e., non-family) homeless population has a substance use disorder and about a quarter of the single adult population experiences some form of mental illness.⁴⁷ By extension, researchers suggest that the odds or likelihood of someone experiencing homelessness increases with the presence of these conditions.⁴⁸

While these rates are high, it is important to note they apply only to the subpopulation of people experiencing homelessness in single-person households—roughly 70 percent of the total population. The remaining 30 percent are members of

multi-person households, and data suggests that substance use disorders, in particular, are much lower within this subpopulation of people experiencing homelessness—11 percent (alcohol) and 13 percent (drugs)—according to a recent study of people staying in family shelters.⁴⁹ Serious mental illness and substance use disorders are also prevalent in the general population. According to the 2019 National Survey on Drug Use and Health, 20.4 million people (twelve years or older) had a substance use disorder—over 7.4 percent of that population—and 5.2 percent of all adults (eighteen years and older) had a serious mental illness. Certainly, these conditions are disproportionately represented in the population of people experiencing homelessness, but two central points are worth making: First, a majority of people experiencing homelessness *don't* have these conditions; and second, the vast majority of people with these conditions never lose their housing.

A related narrative of homelessness emphasizes the lack of institutional care available to people with serious mental illness. By this logic, the de-institutionalization movement that began in the 1950s and accelerated in the 1960s and '70s is to blame for the rise of homelessness in the country.⁵⁰ Proponents of this argument suggest that the closure of institutional settings for people with serious mental illness pushed this cohort of people onto the street. More recent research, however, has questioned this explanation—not least because large reductions in institutional care preceded the rise of homelessness by more than a decade.⁵¹ More plausibly, these researchers argue, the modern rise in homelessness stems from a growing lack of affordable housing. These rising costs exact a significant toll on households with a range of vulnerabilities, including poverty, addiction, and mental illness.

One challenge in explaining homelessness with individual factors is that the presence of various conditions may not provide a causal explanation for homelessness. Indeed, ample evidence suggests that substance abuse is not only a cause of homelessness, but also a consequence.⁵² Given that causal arrows point in both directions, the disproportionate presence of mental illness and substance use in the homeless population makes further sense. Researchers also highlight the well-characterized psychological concept of negative duration dependence. Also known as “scarring,” the phenomenon suggests that the longer a person experiences a condition like homelessness, the harder it is to exit that state. For people without housing, scarring can occur through declining mental and physical health, a reduction or gap in skills or work history, or alteration of one’s physical appearance—all of which make securing housing and employment more challenging.⁵³ People experiencing homelessness suffer from poor sleep and sleep deprivation,⁵⁴ they experience physical and sexual abuse at higher rates than the general population,⁵⁵ and they are lonelier and more separated from important social networks.⁵⁶ These forms of hardship and trauma emphasize how adverse events may lower one’s mental health and emotional well-being.⁵⁷ In other words, the drug use and mental illness that observers frequently blame for homelessness may instead represent a natural bodily response to the harsh and often traumatic conditions that people experiencing homelessness face on a daily basis.

Structural Factors

As noted above, individual attributes often interact with structural forces to produce homelessness. Age, gender, and race, in

isolation, offer limited explanations for homelessness—until they interact with forces of systemic and systematic discrimination (policies and people) that limit access to education, health care, employment, and housing. These same forces incarcerate and evict people of color at disproportionate rates. One consequence of these structural forces is disproportionality in the population of people who experience homelessness. Prominent homelessness scholar Martha Burt summarized this relationship: “Most demographic factors quickly disappear as proximate causes [of homelessness] when other factors representing personal vulnerabilities are available for examination. The *underlying* causes of homelessness, the structural conditions of housing and labor markets that turn vulnerabilities into loss of housing, do not lie within individuals at all and are thus difficult to include in analyses based on individual data.”⁵⁸

Research on such structural factors confronts these causal pathways head-on. Studies on recessions in the 1990s and early 2000s, for example, noted (perhaps unsurprisingly) that homelessness increases during times of economic hardship—although the effect of the Great Recession of 2007–09 on homelessness was less pronounced than that of earlier crises.⁵⁹ Researchers have highlighted that the risk of homelessness increases with poverty,⁶⁰ foreclosures,⁶¹ and high housing costs.⁶² Some have emphasized the effects of regional weather as a potential structural driver of homelessness, with higher temperatures associated with higher rates of homelessness.⁶³ Recent research suggests, however, that the relationship between weather and homelessness is more complicated.⁶⁴ As much of this book deals with structure, we save our discussion of the mechanics of these interactions for later chapters.

A subset of the literature uses inter-community data on U.S. homelessness to generate causal explanations. Our book follows this tradition, in that we leverage communities (cities or counties) as our unit of analysis.⁶⁵ And while most of these studies use the hundreds of CoCs in the country to compare rates of homelessness across the country, examine various time periods, and deploy a wide range of statistical tools, one observation arises again and again: the importance of housing conditions on rates of homelessness. In virtually all studies that analyze intercommunity variation in homelessness rates, measures of rent costs have been identified as significant predictors of homelessness.⁶⁶

One of the challenges of comparing these studies is that their authors draw data from different time periods, specify different analytic models, and break down their data in different manners: urban versus rural CoCs, families versus single-person households, and sheltered versus unsheltered. In aggregate, it's difficult to arrive at a perfectly consistent message about the drivers of homelessness. Beyond the clear message about housing costs, researchers have found that myriad other variables predict higher regional rates of homelessness, including the presence of more single-person households,⁶⁷ low rental market vacancy rates,⁶⁸ a higher percentage of renter households,⁶⁹ higher property values,⁷⁰ lower household income or higher poverty,⁷¹ higher rates of home ownership,⁷² a greater presence of households that recently moved,⁷³ as well as regional demographic attributes like higher percentages of baby boomers or greater proportions of Hispanic households.⁷⁴

In an important study of all CoCs in the country (including urban, suburban, and rural areas), Maria Hanratty used two different statistical models to explain the drivers of homelessness and develop a causal argument. First, she used regression to explain regional variation and found rental costs and poverty

rates to be important predictors of regional rates of homelessness. In a second model specification, to identify changes over time within a given community, she controlled for the presence of unobserved, regionally specific factors (i.e., fixed effects) and found that rental costs were the primary causal explanation for changes in rates of homelessness. Hanratty also identified different effects based on policy variation: Poverty had a stronger causal influence in locations with right-to-shelter policies.⁷⁵

Structural factors may not exert the same effect in all locations. For example, Glynn and Fox suggest that the relationship between rental costs and homelessness is strongest in New York City, Los Angeles, Washington, D.C., and Seattle—some of the cities with the largest per capita rates of homelessness in the country.⁷⁶ Glynn and colleagues characterized inflection points in the rent-homelessness relationship. Homelessness begins to accelerate more rapidly in places where median rent as a percentage of median household income exceeds 32 percent. The inflection point finding parallels the conventional definition of what it means to be burdened by housing costs: the point at which housing costs consume 30 percent of income.⁷⁷ Given this literature, there is little doubt that housing market factors—notably, rent levels—play an important role in driving homelessness, even if these effects may vary based on geographic context.⁷⁸

Bad Luck

Writing for Vox, the author Veronica Harnish notes: “There are so many ways to get down on your luck, or become homeless, and so few means to escape. Economic inequality and a system built to perpetuate it is the problem—homelessness is the result for people without a safety net.”⁷⁹ At the time she penned the

essay in question, Harnish had been homeless three times. She had jobs, mostly government contract work. But she didn't have a lot of savings, and upon losing a job, she couldn't afford the rent and was usually left sleeping in her car. It wasn't that she wasn't trying: It was just that the deck was stacked against her. Even her employer, the public sector, didn't quite have what she needed. "Impoverished, working single women without children do not get top priority on long waitlists for subsidized housing, rapid rehousing, or other government services or benefits," she writes.⁸⁰

The final category of explanations for homelessness that arises in academic and popular narratives is that of bad luck. Given the dichotomy outlined above—between structural and individual factors—we might consider luck as another individual-level factor that can increase the risk of homelessness. Examples of negative luck include job loss, injury or illness, breakdown of a car, breakdown of personal relationships, and many other factors that can lead to eviction or foreclosure.⁸¹ Certainly, not all bad luck produces a spell of homelessness. Some households hold other assets or resources that protect them from an incident of bad luck cascading into a severe personal crisis. Some people, like Harnish, don't have a backup. Marah Curtis and colleagues, for example, studied a health shock—the birth of a child with a severe health condition—to understand how unexpected life events impact the risk of experiencing homelessness. In a finding consistent with many theories of homelessness, Curtis found "the shock substantially increases the likelihood of family homelessness, particularly in cities with high housing costs. The findings are consistent with the economic theory of homelessness, which posits that homelessness results from a conjunction of adverse circumstances in which housing markets and individual characteristics collide."⁸² In this book, we are interested in these collisions.

WHAT ARE THE CONSEQUENCES OF HOMELESSNESS?

Research demonstrates that even short spells of homelessness can be damaging to the people who experience it, especially children. Other consequences of urban homelessness exist at the community level: some quantifiable—such as public spending on emergency health and public safety, as well as lost tourism revenue—and others less tangible, including the sadness, discomfort, shame, or anger that people with housing may feel in the face of people without it.

For adults, the consequences of homelessness are dire. People who experience homelessness die at earlier ages,⁸³ contract infectious diseases at higher rates,⁸⁴ are hospitalized at earlier ages and make more trips to the emergency room,⁸⁵ are more likely to be victims of physical and sexual assault,⁸⁶ and misuse substances at higher rates.⁸⁷ Researchers have also demonstrated that the risks and stress associated with homelessness contribute to higher rates of mental illness among the chronically homeless population.⁸⁸

The life-long consequences of homelessness in childhood are particularly troubling given the long-lasting, negative effects. Research on child and youth homelessness reports a range of negative outcomes, including developmental delays for young children,⁸⁹ high levels of anxiety,⁹⁰ poor health outcomes,⁹¹ inadequate preventive medical care,⁹² higher levels of emotional and behavior problems,⁹³ and academic underachievement and delays.⁹⁴ Homeless youth are also disproportionately exposed to abuse of all types, including sexual trauma.⁹⁵

For researchers, journalists, and members of the general public alike, it is easy and convenient to pathologize homelessness: highlighting the mental and physical causes and consequences

of this condition that are most conspicuous and quantifiable. But the observed and more readily measurable effects of homelessness fail to capture the harmful emotional consequences, as well. Homeless adults report much higher rates of loneliness than do adults who are housed.⁹⁶ Children who experience homelessness are much more likely to persistently feel unsafe than children with housing.⁹⁷ Naomi Thulien and colleagues conducted a qualitative study of formerly homeless youth in Toronto about their experiences attempting to effectively integrate back into (housed) society. The summary of their findings underscores the significant emotional toll of experiences with homelessness: “Unaffordable housing, limited education, inadequate employment opportunities, poverty-level income, and limited social capital made it remarkably challenging for the young people to move forward. As the study progressed, the participants’ ability to formulate long-range plans were impeded as they were forced to focus on day-to-day existence. Over time, living in a perpetual state of poverty led to feelings of ‘outsiderness,’ viewing life as a game of chance, and isolation.”⁹⁸

Numerous studies have estimated the annual community costs of homelessness, but these estimates vary considerably. Most frequently, cost studies are based on the service histories of people experiencing homelessness. Examples of increases in public service use related to homelessness include upticks in emergency room visits, police and fire departments responding to homelessness-related calls, public health expenditures, and the direct costs associated with operating a municipal homelessness response system. In a literature review on the costs and benefits of the Housing First approach—a collection of policies that aim to eliminate barriers to housing programs for people experiencing homelessness—Ly and Latimer highlighted studies

from the United States and Canada that show annual costs of homelessness between \$30,000 and \$100,000 per person.⁹⁹ All the studies were conducted between 2000 and 2015. A study using data from Australia reported people experiencing homelessness used an average of \$48,000 of government services over the course of a year.¹⁰⁰ The study included costs associated with “police, prison, probation, parole, courts, emergency department, hospital-admitted patients, ambulance, mental health, and homelessness services data.”¹⁰¹

The benefit of cost studies is that they help to benchmark the significant public expenditures associated with homelessness, highlight alternatives to this spending, and draw our attention to the manners in which the public sector is (intentionally or otherwise) responding to the crisis at hand. According to homelessness researcher Dennis Culhane, “An important benefit of the analyses of homelessness services utilization and costs is that this research can demonstrate that people who experience homelessness do not just use shelters, but are often the clients, sometimes the well-known clients, of these larger and more intensively funded service systems.”¹⁰²

In addition to the obvious system-wide costs attributed to homelessness, other ancillary costs are frequently ignored—and these costs may be borne by people who do not experience homelessness. These costs don’t need to be financial in nature. (Consider feelings of guilt or fear in the presence of people experiencing homelessness.) Many housed urban dwellers have concerns—whether humanitarian or spiteful—related to issues of cleanliness and safety frequently associated with unsheltered homelessness. In short, homelessness exacts a considerable toll on society, and those tangible and intangible costs cannot be ignored. Frustrations or fears related to homelessness have

prompted cities to respond aggressively to police or control the unhoused in an effort to mitigate these costs.

Critical sociologists, urbanists, and geographers have written extensively about exclusionary efforts that cities have undertaken to hide and/or punish the poor. The motivation for these punitive approaches is often financial: The homeless, and other people living on the margins of society, are bad for business. According to geographer Geoffrey DeVerteuil, to attract capital and the middle class, “cities must create positive images for themselves, especially with regards to the all-important tourism and convention industry. With less room to maneuver, cities are increasingly obliged to ‘hide’ the growing gap between rich and poor in order to remain competitive, leading to a mandatory punitive response to visible urban problems.” DeVerteuil goes on to quote the geographer Gordon MacLeod: “The continuous renaissance of the entrepreneurial city [is] tightly ‘disciplined’ through a range of architectural forms and institutional practices so that the enhancement of a city’s image is not compromised by the visible presence of . . . very marginalized groups.”¹⁰³ If you’ve ever seen concrete spikes lining the perimeter of a building, you know what MacLeod is getting at.

We see echoes of the financial logic in press accounts about the negative impact of homelessness on local commerce. Writers frequently highlight the link between unsheltered homelessness and either real or perceived reductions in commerce and tourism.¹⁰⁴ Reports suggest that tourism and conference business have suffered in certain cities due to concerns over homeless encampments, public safety, and a general lack of cleanliness. Oracle Corporation’s “Open World” conference moved to Las Vegas from San Francisco over concerns associated with hotel costs and “poor street conditions.”¹⁰⁵ Newspapers have chronicled

the frustrations of tourists who have confronted the unsheltered homelessness crisis in West Coast cities. Take Glen Commins, a tourist from Tennessee, who recently participated in an interview with the Seattle ABC affiliate, KOMO News, in front of the iconic Ivar's waterfront seafood restaurant. "This is your touristy spot, you know, and it looks dirty," he said. "It makes the city look dirty and this is a cool city."¹⁰⁶ For people like Commins—and maybe businesses like Ivar's—these costs are real. While difficult to calculate, the myriad costs associated with the homelessness crisis are borne by a wide variety of a city's people.

HOW DO WE STOP OR PREVENT HOMELESSNESS?

In an echo of the literature that examines the causes of homelessness, studies focused on ending or preventing homelessness can also be divided by unit of observation. While some researchers focus on the effectiveness of specific interventions—programs designed to prevent or end homelessness—for specific types of people, others seek to understand how various treatments affect the rate of homelessness within a particular region.

While we can understand the causes of homelessness at the individual or family level as a somewhat complex interaction between individual factors, structural drivers, and misfortune, understanding responses to homelessness is a more straightforward task. In study after study, the most effective treatment for homelessness is housing. In some cases, this housing comes in the form of rental assistance; in others, it might be a subsidized housing unit with supportive services. In all cases, the housing unit in question is the difference between a homelessness crisis and the time and space needed to get back on one's feet. The evidence is also clear that attempting to resolve one's serious

mental illness or substance use conditions in isolation fails to resolve one's homelessness crisis, because safe and stable housing is essential to a healthy and productive life. Treatment of individual pathologies will not end homelessness.¹⁰⁷ Providing housing as a human right, not as a good or service available only to those who can afford it, is the key. In a May 2020 editorial in the *New York Times*, Benjamin Appelbaum wrote, "The federal government could render homelessness rare, brief and nonrecurring. The cure for homelessness is housing."¹⁰⁸

In their book *In the Midst of Plenty: Homelessness and What to Do About It*, Marybeth Shinn and Jill Khadduri devote significant attention to efforts to end and prevent homelessness at the individual or family level. Given the evidence base, they suggest different housing interventions for different sub-populations of people experiencing homelessness. For families, Shinn and Khadduri argue long-term rental subsidies are the most effective policy. Primary support for this argument comes from the Family Options study.¹⁰⁹ This study was a federal trial in which long-term housing vouchers (mostly Housing Choice Vouchers) were provided to families living in shelter. Families who were able to use the rental support to lease a unit were far less likely than other groups—who received short-term rental subsidies and transitional housing—to return to shelter.

For single adults experiencing homelessness, the task is more difficult. While many families are likely to end a bout of homelessness with housing support, many homeless individuals—especially those who are chronically homeless—may require housing *and* other supportive services. A central debate in homelessness policy over the past two decades has pivoted on the question of which of these needs ought to be met first. Here, the best research appears to suggest that the most promising

intervention for individuals experiencing chronic homelessness is the provision of housing itself under a supportive housing model (including via the Housing First approach), in which support services are voluntary as opposed to mandated.¹¹⁰ In contrast, researchers have found the treatment-first model—in which serious mental illness or substance use disorders are treated prior to housing program participation—to be less effective than public and nonprofit programs that provide housing without any requirement for treatment.¹¹¹ Ultimately, most contemporary scholars and policy analysts have concluded that permanent housing programs with voluntary support services offer the most effective intervention for single adults experiencing homelessness.¹¹²

A second thread of research considers whether investments to end or prevent homelessness alter rates of homelessness at a regional level. But because housing interventions are rarely conducted in a manner that lends itself to analysis via the scientific method—there is no randomized control trial of, say, doubling homelessness service-delivery-budgets—determining the true comparative efficacy of these programs and investments is more difficult. Homelessness occurs within a dynamic housing and support system in which housing availability and rents evolve over time—as do the services and supports available to households. In many instances, the best that researchers can do is observe a change in one or more of these factors and assess whether there's a corresponding effect on the outcomes of interest: rates of homelessness in a given region. Numerous studies, for example, have sought to characterize the relationship between funding (typically federal funding) for a public-sector homelessness response and homelessness. The underlying question of this type of research is a fair one: Do federal investments

in homelessness reduce homelessness? As cited above, existing literature illustrates that a range of programs reduce homelessness at an individual level, so the question here is whether we can observe these effects at a community level.

Given the research conducted over the last decade, the relationship between federal investments in homelessness and rates of homelessness is frustratingly mixed. A common theme in this literature—whether stated or unstated—is the issue of moral hazard. Some argue that additional investments in shelter and permanent supportive housing (PSH) may create incentives for people experiencing homelessness to use these services at higher rates and for longer periods of time.¹¹³ The first studies to use HUD PIT counts to estimate the relationship between federal funding for homelessness and rates of homelessness found modest, negative relationships between the two factors—that is, more spending, less homelessness.¹¹⁴ Byrne and colleagues (2014) documented a modest effect of investments in permanent supportive housing on the size of the chronically homeless population, and Moulton (2013) saw this population shrink with more federal spending on homelessness in a given region. In another study of the effect of PSH investments, Igor Popov found a modest reduction in total homelessness from additional PSH investments.¹¹⁵ More recent studies have examined subpopulations of people experiencing homelessness and reported varying effects of federal spending. Popov, for example, reported that federal homelessness investments reduce the individual unsheltered count—as many unsheltered individuals move into shelter—while greater total investments increase family homelessness in a given region, as additional housing and shelter capacity may draw families from other regions or from other precariously housed situations toward the sites of investment.

In an echo of the findings from Popov, David Lucas suggested that greater federal investments in homelessness increase rates of sheltered homelessness: Federal funding can significantly increase shelter capacity, so the public homelessness response system can accommodate more people—either coming from unsheltered locations or from other precariously housed situations.¹¹⁶ In one case, the overall homeless count increases (if people enter the system from, for example, a doubled-up living situation), while in the other case (an unsheltered person moving into shelter), there is no change in the overall level of homelessness.

Given mixed evidence for the efficacy of federal investments in homelessness, critics may wonder whether existing programs should see their funding increased—or even continued. A few points are worth making. First, for many people experiencing homelessness, living in a quality shelter is preferable to living unsheltered on the street. By extension, investments that fail to reduce overall levels of homelessness—but instead shift homelessness from the street into shelters—ought not be viewed as worthless or ineffective, as they’re responding to people’s immediate needs.

Second, that greater investments in the homelessness response system sometimes appear to pull people into that system suggests that there are many precariously housed people who desperately need housing. We argue that findings related to pull factors into homelessness imply a housing crisis that runs far deeper than headline numbers describe. If anything, these studies emphasize the necessity of continuing to provide adequate quantities of shelter and PSH—while also addressing the broader housing market conditions that create the demand for homelessness services.

Most of the studies highlighted thus far have examined the relationship between investments in the homelessness system itself (including temporary and permanent housing programs like emergency shelters, permanent supportive housing, and transitional housing) as opposed to the overall supply of affordable housing in a given region. When researchers analyzed the relationship between affordable housing built with Low-Income Housing Tax Credits and rates of homelessness within a community, they reported that while construction of affordable units did not alter the level of homelessness in a given neighborhood, it did reduce the level of homelessness at a county level.¹¹⁷ This finding offers important evidence about the relationship between housing supply, affordability, and the level of homelessness in a community. Though some researchers question the efficacy of federal investments in homelessness, most agree that lower housing prices will help reduce rates of homelessness.¹¹⁸ This agreement on housing costs as a mechanism to reduce rates of homelessness highlights the structural changes—beyond conventional homelessness policies and programs—needed to prevent the condition at its root.

With a broader understanding of homelessness—who experiences it, how it has changed over time, its causal drivers, its effects, and efforts to end or prevent it—we now turn our attention to the book's central purpose: explaining regional variation in rates of homelessness.